



**BEST PRACTICES
FOR
DISTRIBUTED TEAMS**

sage innovation labs

Leadership & Product Development

- **Distributed Leadership**
 - Establish leadership and key team roles at each location
 - Co-locate key project lead roles
 - Create a clear chain of command
 - Align concept and delivery teams by functional area
- **Product Development**
 - Maintain product backlog with clear separation and ownership of features by each team
 - Establish a product owner proxy if the real product owner is not available at each location
 - For each team, provide a single voice of the customer either via the product owner or proxy for each team location
 - Write stories as teams and create vertical slices of functionality

Communication & Interaction

- **Communication Channels**

- Provide clear and open communication
- Encourage everyone to be open and honest
- Provide cross-site communication via on-site person as proxy
- Eliminate ambiguity and actively listen for confusion

- **Team Interaction**

- Provide means for everyone to reach each other at any time
- Ask open-ended questions to increase communication
- For remote teams, ask more than the usual number of questions to increase engagement
- Arrange face-to-face interaction at least 1-2 times per year
- Co-locate teams for 1-2 weeks during key periods of a project
- Provide for staff rotation between teams and locations

Project Management & Methodology

- **Project Management**

- Focus on reduce friction in the process
- Share daily reports with everyone
- Distribute work equally assigning ownership to individuals
- Share information to be reviewed tomorrow with local and remote teams at the end of the day

- **Agile Methodology**

- Provide vision and expected outcomes for every sprint
- Conduct team retrospective and reflection at end of sprint
- Conduct strong face-to-face project kickoff in-person
 - Allows everyone to get to know one another
 - Allows everyone to understand their impact on the project

Meetings & Time Management

- **Team Meetings**
 - Conduct daily stand-ups
 - Hold post-scrum working session after daily scrum
 - Hold frequent short demos
 - Consider holding a show-and-tell hour periodically for developers to showcase individual work
 - Hold daily developer-only scrum for each team
 - Time-box all meetings providing clear agenda and outcomes
- **Time Management**
 - Understand and plan for time zone differences
 - Adjust working hours for all sites to maximize overlap while considering personal time
 - Schedule late-night & early-morning work well ahead of time

Team Dynamics & Composition

- **Team Composition**

- Focus on hiring more social team members
- Employ project managers as relationship managers
- Ensure remote engineers are not treated as augmented team members reporting into remote lead
- Strive for following optimal team ratio
 - 1 Product Manager : 1 UX : 4-5 Developers : 1-2 QA per team
 - 1 Project Manager & 1-2 Architects per project

- **Team Empowerment**

- Give individual teams freedom to operate in their own space
- Empower the team to push back
- Build personas to characterize your most common team scenarios, behavior and needs

Development & Architecture

- **Development Efforts**
 - Setup mentoring and buddies for developers
 - Setup pair programming where possible
 - Conduct code reviews with local and remote teams
- **Shared Architecture**
 - Simplify integration between systems
 - Have a clear architecture and design guidelines across teams
 - Shared infrastructure solution benefits multiple teams

Training & Documentation

- **Training and Knowledge Sharing**
 - Use short videos to share knowledge among the team
 - Distributed pairing of individuals for sharing of information
 - Increase the amount of shared context between teams
 - Set a policy that everyone should understand all artifacts
 - Cross train across sites
- **Documentation Standards**
 - Define basic guidelines on processes
 - Put everything in writing
 - Establishing a clear understanding of what to expect
 - Use an informal style

Technology & Tools

- **Efficient Technology Use**
 - Use technology to bring the group together
 - Don't reinvent the wheel
 - Use the team's profile and needs to drive decisions
- **Technology Considerations**
 - Limit use of email and encourage real-time collaboration via instant messaging and chat
 - Use audio and video conferencing for meetings
 - Provide online and offline team workspaces for document sharing and discussions
 - Automate software development lifecycle